

KORANTINE RITES

By Jonathan Drake

Designing a quasi-ancient society for Mythras and other RPGs

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This article uses a little bit of what we know about real world history to provide some guidance on creating a plausible *fantasy* world of city-states and ancient empires. If it is a real-world historical setting you are after then I would recommend the immensely detailed *Mythic Rome*, or the Spanish-language and excellent-looking *Mediterraneo Mitico*, both of which are available from The Design Mechanism

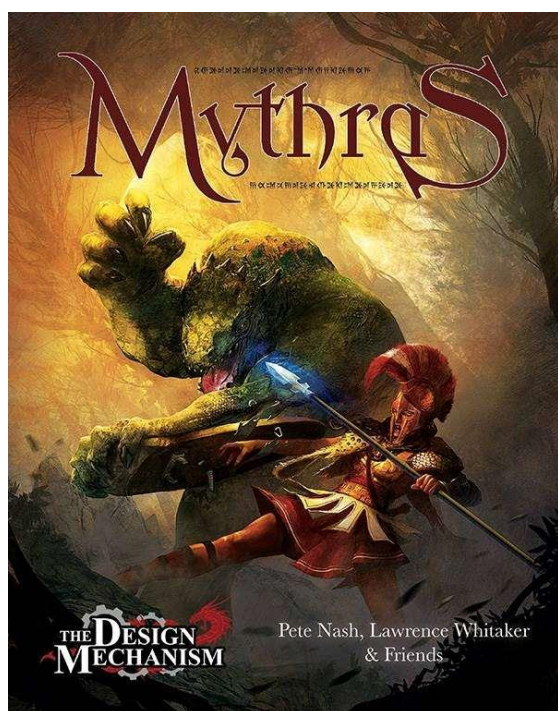
Back in 1982 White Dwarf magazine published a pair of articles on the subject of 'Designing a Quasi-Medieval Society for D&D', by Paul Vernon¹. These and the 'Town Planner' articles that followed offered guidance on how to apply a bit of common sense to the economics of the game. Why, Vernon asked, would an NPC hireling take the wages on offer in the Dungeon Master's Guide to carry your Adventuring gear when the Players' Handbook states a whole day's labour will do no more than buy him a couple of pints of ale? But the bigger objective of Vernon's articles was much more ambitious: to enable a Games Master to flesh out a credible

and internally consistent fantasy world grounded in some historical realities of Middle-Ages Europe. If roleplaying games began with the shared language of a pseudo-medieval world as the implied setting of D&D, over the years almost every age of history has been plundered for inspiration, and sometimes realistic detail, to flesh out a fantasy. Given how much time it takes just to prep a game, the prospect of putting even more hours into world-building research to help inspire or shape your setting can be pretty daunting. So what follows is a kind of user's manual for creating and running a quasi-*ancient* rather than a quasi-

¹ WD 29 (Pt1) and WD30 (Pt2). The Town Planner articles that followed appear in WD 31, 32 and 33

medieval fantasy setting. It's entirely appropriate that an article about designing a quasi-ancient society should be targeted at the D100 family of games, since it was the original RuneQuest game that took RPGs into worlds with an ancient feel for the first time.

For me, *Mythras* is the current Rolls Royce engine for D100 fantasy, and its default setting used in the *Mythras Core Rulebook* is the ancient-style city-state of Meeros. The poster-girl for Meeros is the warrior Anathaym, depicted in fine classical style complete with bronze muscled cuirass and iconic Corinthian helmet. If you find a map of Meeros itself (and you will if you take a look in the *Mythras Game Master's Pack*), you will see it also has good classical parentage – it's actually a map of the famous ancient Greek city of Miletus, situated on the shores of what is now Turkey. We only get glimpses of Anathayms' world in the *Mythras Core Rulebook*, but there's more to learn from a series of published adventures (*Meeros Falling*, *Meeros Doomed*, *Sariniya's Curse* and *Xamoxis' Cleansing*).



My own book, *Shores of Korantia*, presents another quasi-ancient setting for *Mythras*, and dropping Meeros into it to make use of its engaging characters and adventures is very easily done. *Korantia* details a culture made up of dozens of city-states of which Meeros could be one, and is situated in a wider world called Thennla. So there are already some good published resources for quasi-ancient gaming in *Mythras*, but if you want to create your own, or expand on what's there while keeping things ancient, this article is for you.

This article is *not* about Bronze Age settings. In RPG circles it seems commonplace to use Bronze Age as a term encompassing all things ancient to differentiate from settings that are medieval in inspiration. Bronze Age properly relates only to real world cultures that existed before the 1st Millennium BCE such as Pharaonic Egypt, the Sumerians, Babylonians, Hittites, Mycenaeans and Minoans². In the *Mythras* line, the excellent *Mythic Babylon* is set precisely in that frame. But here the intention is to emulate civilizations of the 1st Millennium BCE and early 1st Millennium CE, when the Bronze Age already lies centuries in the past, and for most people is only glimpsed through old myths and legends.

We are now squarely in the Iron Age, and our inspiration is the Mediterranean world where Greece and Rome take centre stage. These times are quite different. Iron has changed the world. Bronze needs two metals (copper and tin) to be brought along different trade routes to where they can be alloyed and worked. Powerful people who enable that trade and control distribution of the end product their favourites and dependants are a key feature of Bronze Age societies. But iron is relatively close at hand, abundant, doesn't need alloying and is increasingly cheap. Once you can generate the temperatures needed to extract and work it, iron puts metalwork in the hands of

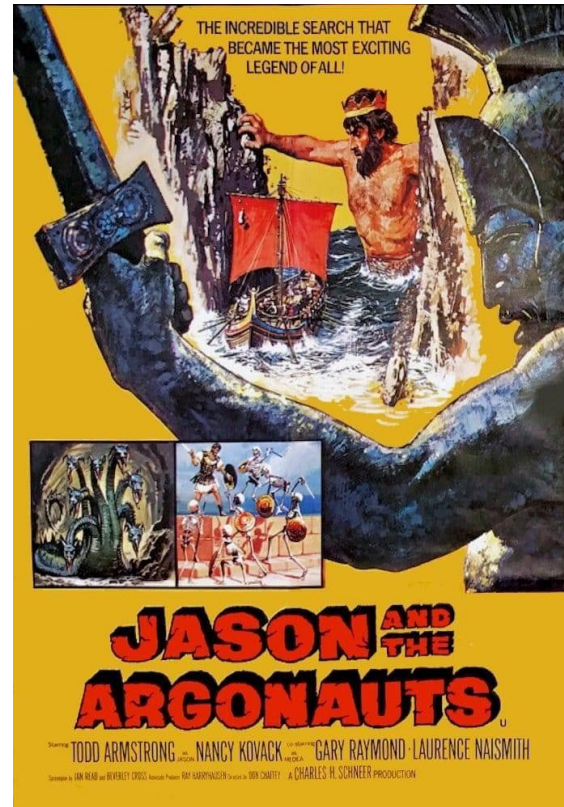
² Bronze Age to Iron Age transition dates vary by region and some creep further into the 1st Millennium BC. Egypt is a good case in point

anyone and everyone, used for even the simplest of tools. Bronze is still preferred for ornamental work because of its attractive colour and resistance to corrosion, including for the fanciest armours.

Another new technology that sets this time apart from the preceding Bronze Age is the alphabet, a supremely flexible way of writing that makes it a simple task to record and share information and ideas in any number of languages. The old cuneiform and hieroglyphic scripts used in Egypt and Mesopotamia are slowly dying out. The alphabet is only invented once, then adapted to different letter forms and sounds by each culture that takes it up. Reading and writing, like ironwork, can become widespread and democratised.

So what are the characteristics of a quasi-ancient world? Is it just an aesthetic – a different corridor in history’s vast costume store in which you will find many short tunics and wraparound cloaks but definitely no trousers? Is it the picturesque backdrop of lovely pillared temples, graceful statues, glittering seas and a lot more sunshine than your average medieval fantasy? These can be all you need to recreate the vibe of a sword-and-sandal movie like *Clash of the Titans* (1981), or *Jason and the Argonauts* (1963) or *Troy* (2004). But if we are going for a deeper sense of immersion into a different time and place, quasi-ancient has, in my view, a lot more to offer than quasi-medieval, and rewards a deeper investigation into what makes it unique rather than just offering a different set of costumes, sets and a lot of names ending in -os and -us (or -e and -a).

Some things are much the same as you would find in a Medieval setting. Human civilisation is driven by the proceeds, limitations and risks of agriculture. Having enough to eat to survive, to support and care for your family is quite enough of a challenge even before any marauding hordes of Chaos arrive to ruin your day. The technologies available are more or less the same as in medieval times, with some



important exceptions, like the lack of horse collars, heavy ploughs and wheelbarrows. Energy comes from burning wood and charcoal – there is no fossil fuel use except as novelty, and while in medieval Europe timber was plentiful, in some of the regions that were home to ancient civilisation wood is a scarce resource and so energy costs can be very expensive. But what’s really different from what went before, or came afterwards, is the way people organise themselves.

In real world history the 1st Millennium BCE sees the rise of hundreds of independent city-states around the Mediterranean region, thanks to a period of prolonged growth and development. This has allowed for lots of people to settle permanently in close proximity, for family units to grow in size and number, and for permanently occupied cities to become commonplace as centres of commerce, religion, politics and defence. If there is one feature of a quasi-ancient setting it is this – that the Adventurers and the NPCs they interact with may identify themselves with a particular land, lineage, tribe or people, but the key distinction is now whether you are a *citizen*, and if so, of

what city.³ The city they call home is likely packed with houses and public buildings sporting tiled rooves, with a clutch of pillared temples at its heart, some broad plazas where people meet and all encompassed by a fine city wall.

It's not unusual in fantasy movies and series to get a great wide shot of an impressive walled city in the middle of what appears to be a wilderness. Even if that does look a little unrealistic when you stop to think about it, how much do we really care? It's entirely possible to just focus on the story and action and skate over the rest, just like those movies. But if you are in for a deep dive into the inner workings of your setting, whether as a player or a GM, a basic grasp of how that setting works, and what makes it tick, can be really useful. It can help root your Adventurers in their community by understanding what their social status means and, perhaps more importantly, how that can change. It gives you some idea of how to gauge appropriate levels of reward, and what the adventurers can spend their loot on and how much it costs. If you know how fast a Player Character or NPC burns through their cash until their next adventure, that tells you when they may have to find paid work, and how much they may be able to make. If the Adventurers strike it rich enough to land themselves a patch of land, a lordly estate, or even a kingdom, what are the challenges and opportunities on offer? A bit of thought into what the vast majority of people in your world spend their time doing can be illuminating. Figuring out the priorities and preoccupations of your world's inhabitants will not only help the world come alive but will provide plenty of story hooks and plot motivations – and above all, helps you paint a picture of what your world is like.

³ Of course there were people in the regions covered by this article who never embraced the whole city-state arrangement and instead formed leagues of scattered communities that shared lineage (real or imagined), customs, language and cults.

A Hero Goes Shopping

My starting point is Anathaym, the would-be hero whose unfolding career provides the rulebook example text for Mythras. As we follow Anathaym's preparation for her forthcoming adventures in the Mythras Core Rulebook (CRB), we discover her classic 'hoplite' panoply costs something like 820SP (Silver Pieces) for the basics of spear (20), the essential shield (300) and helmet (500). The rest of her armour, perhaps a luxury but, especially given Anathaym's aristocratic origins, entirely appropriate to a front-rank fighter, comes in at another 3,000SP. Her sword has a list price of 100SP, although poor Anathaym is out-witted in negotiations by the sword-maker and pays 125SP. So the fine set of equipment in which she is decked out on the cover of the rulebook comes to just under 4,000SP. That is, according to the Economics chapter of the same rulebook, equivalent to the earnings of a skilled artisan with their own business for about two and a half years⁴. In modern terms, using Median US earnings as a base, that's equivalent to about \$100,000, or for the European Union, about €82,500⁵. It could be that in Meeros the raw materials required are very, very expensive, or



⁴ The example provided for a baker with his own business who hopes to earn twice the listed Minimum Maintenance Cost for his Social Class, Mythras CRB p.55

⁵ Based on 2021 census information. These figures are for Mean (US) and Average (EU) individual, not

that craftsmen work very, very slowly and charge by the day. To be fair when Ananthaym's panoply of hoplite shield, Corinthian helmet and bronze armour first came into vogue in Ancient Greece (around 7th Century BCE), it was for a while the preserve of elite warrior-aristocrats. But if you are building a quasi-*ancient* world one of the first tests is whether ordinary folk are able to equip themselves to serve their city as part of a militia of warrior-citizens. These are not a rag-tag bunch of total amateurs assembling for home defence while the army does the real work. They *are* the army. In many ways it is what the whole social system is built on. Some are so poor as to have to opt for the skirmish line, armed with a sling or javelin, even just a rock - or to pull on an oar in a war galley armed with no more than a cushion to minimise the chafing. But in ancient city-states most people with a living - a modest farm or a business as an artisan or skilled worker - should be able to take their place in the 'phalanx', and for that you need to bring a spear and hoplite shield to the party. If we set aside Ananthaym's aristocratic extravagance (something ancient folk were also familiar with), we are still left with the fact that, using the CRB price lists, a regular citizen answering their city's call would have to fork out at least 320SP to acquire the absolute basics, and still not have a helmet, let alone any armour. Historical evidence suggests these costs may be grossly inflated, and in fact a basic panoply (including a helmet) should cost about one month's income for an average citizen.

That's the kind of question that sent me off in the direction of exploring the realities of ancient economies and what that means for designing a quasi-ancient fantasy setting. It is why *Shores of Korantia* has a very different price list of its own that isn't compatible with the CRB. Mythras isn't a simulation, and it is not unusual in fantasy roleplaying games for arms and armour to be priced very expensively, as they

are a route for player-characters to upgrade in readiness for bigger and more dangerous challenges ahead. Perhaps this is also a legacy of quasi-medieval settings where equipping oneself in a style appropriate to a knight is something far beyond the reach of common folk. But the issue really comes down to exploring what makes a quasi-ancient setting unique, and in doing so trying to set up the economics of the setting to support that. So I looked to the real world for answers. Presented with a very patchy array of available data scattered across centuries of history, widely different contexts, and buried in a lot of different modern publications, I did my best to build things from the ground up, and have a rationale, rather than just eyeball it. It was soon apparent that given how much ancient pricing and monetary systems could vary over time and space, a yardstick was needed. In the White Dwarf article referred to earlier, Paul Vernon made use of the price of ale as his yardstick. For my purposes, in exploring a world that really didn't pay much attention to any form of beer, the price of grain quickly presented itself as the most useful tool.

The Grain Standard

A typical measure in which grain is bought and sold is the *peck*. That's an Attic (Athenian) *hecteus* or a Roman *modius*. This is a dry measure of volume, a little under 9 litres, that amounts to roughly 6.67kg of wheat, a bit less of lighter grains like barley. Incidentally, there are four pecks to a *bushel* - unless you are a Roman, when there are three, or a Greek, when there are six. The point is, the peck is a rough but near universal measure, and grain is the essential commodity of an ancient economy. By comparing the price of one peck of grain to the price of other goods and services in the same historical time period, we can calibrate price

household income. Our baker is probably above average

lists. We can peg the price of 1 peck of grain at 1 Silver Piece (SP). It can produce 16-20 loaves of bread, and I'm going to peg those at 1 Bronze Piece (BP) each. A Silver Piece also rather usefully lines up well with a typical day's wages for a labourer, so that helps connect the price of food with earnings and the cost of labour.

REAL WORLD US FANTASY WORLD

As ancient societies are the product of the environment as well as of people, it's important to state a few background assumptions. If some of these fundamentals in your fantasy world are materially different it can have interesting knock-on effects to some of the information and rules suggestions given here.

- 1) The quasi-ancient world as defined here is essentially a Mediterranean world. It's hot and dry in the Summer, the rains mostly come in the winter and have to last you right through to harvest time in the middle of the year. Mountainous terrain and rugged coasts allow cities to grow up as independent communities with clear natural borders but often restrict their room to expand and grow. The sea connects people across long distances - goods, people, news and ideas can spread far and fast. So can pirates and invading armies. Connection to millennia-old civilisations such as Egypt or Babylon have been an essential spur to growth and development.
- 2) We'll be looking at agriculture quite closely, so I am assuming the year in your setting is approximately 360 days long. Agriculture makes use of similar crops to real world examples and achieves similar yields. Simple fallow field practices, leaving some of your fields uncultivated each year to allow land to recover its fertility, are standard, crop rotation is not unknown. While the available food supply



includes a wide variety of different grains, oil, fruit, vegetables, meats, fish etc, some form of grain provides the vast majority of all calories consumed.

- 3) The magical or supernatural elements of your setting do not materially affect crop yields, infant mortality, gender roles, the dependability of rainfall, or the occurrence of natural phenomena such as famine, drought and disease, extreme weather and climate change (but we will look later at how magic might change things in important ways).

This article plucks information from a thousand years of history and diverse geographical regions, looking for common characteristics and making gross generalisations. It is about simplifying things to help with building your world, There are plenty of good books out there where you can dig deeper into ancient economics if you want to, that will help you model a specific point and place in time like Classical Athens, Hellenistic Alexandria or Rome in the Middle Republic. Some of those I have found especially useful will be listed in an Appendix.

THE ERAS OF ANTIQUITY

While different regions and lands developed at different rates, overall the 1st Millennium BCE is one of steady growth in populations, city sizes, social complexity and size of the economy. Having an idea of the key stages as historians often tend to bracket them may help you cherry-pick, tweak and customise the suggestions given here. What follows are very schematic and broad brush-stroke descriptions. They will not be entirely true for any specific place in time, but should provide useful general guidelines.

The Olden Times

Back before people wrote down any histories or kept any records, the world was a stage for high-born heroes, men and women who traced their lineage back to the gods. These men, each a lord in his own right, ruled kingdoms or chiefdoms big and small – some so small to be

no more than a collection of villages. They fought, raided for cattle, feasted and drank, listening to their storied exploits sung by bards as they reclined in the company of other heroes. Being remembered in epic song was to be immortalised. They competed in games of physical prowess, raced chariots pulled by teams of magnificent horses. They would sometimes gather (when it suited them) to debate and decide important matters, or to dispense justice, in front of the assembled common folk whose only voice was to cheer (or quietly grumble) at the fine words spoken with lordly eloquence. They ventured abroad seek glory, to raid, plunder and even to trade. Their wealth was measured in herds, flocks and fields, iron, bronze, silver and gold, but also in storied treasures and artefacts of exquisite workmanship given added lustre by the their pedigree of makers and former owners: who they were gifted to and by whom. When they died they were burned on great funeral pyres amid more songs, more feasting, and sacrifices – sometimes human sacrifices. Some would be forever remembered as founders of nations and cities, many would perish as they followed their calling to war for the sake of war, prowess in battle the culminating expression of their aristocratic excellence. A favoured few would be offered a seat among the gods because they so far surpassed other mortals. Those times are past, but they are always remembered...

Archaic World (Culture Type: Barbarian)



The Age of Heroes has receded into legend. Wealthy aristocrats still hold power, and they still chase the dream of being like those heroes of old. They dine and drink in rooms hung with armour and weapons, listening to epic poems and shooting the breeze about the exploits of their heroic ancestors. They know their station in life compels them to step up in war and peace

to be leaders, to fight in the front rank, to know what is the right thing to do, because they are rich enough to be free of common concerns like toiling in the fields or where your next meal is coming from that afflict the lower orders.

But now they don't have it all their way. The many, the poor, the mean and lowly, those with no lineage to speak of, increasingly have a voice. And a lot of them have spears. The world is a bigger place. The wandering hero with his little entourage of armed retainers is increasingly looking like nothing more than a good adventure story. Making war, building the city, ruling the land, is now a cooperative venture where rich and poor must work together. A city and its people are starting to be bigger than the partisan interests of any one aristocratic family, or any tribe or faction among the people. So we need a formal set of rules by which everyone gets along.

This is where the *lawgivers* come in. These are wise sages, sometimes local but often consultants brought in from outside, who give the city a set of laws, a constitution, by which all the people know what their rights and where they stand. Wise lawgivers aim for 'balance', which in these times usually means some form of oligarchy, where leading positions are restricted to rich aristocrats and political voice is restricted to those who can equip themselves to fight to defend their property and rights. Once you have your shiny new laws you can use the alphabet to write them down, carved in stone to be displayed in public. Now, the high-ups cannot use ancient unwritten laws and customs to their own advantage as they sit in judgement, because even ordinary folk can now refer to the laws for themselves, and justice becomes available to all.

Sometimes one of the city's aristocrats makes a successful play for sole power, usually with the connivance of some numerically significant part of the wider population that enables him to bat aside those who stand in his way. An autocrat may style himself a king. In some places the job title still exists, even if it is likely to be a post to which you can be elected for life to do a lot of ceremonial and ritual stuff rather than actually ruling. But often an autocrat who

actually does exercise real power is called a *tyrant*, no matter whether he rules justly and well or tyrannically. And while tyrants' reigns are often short-lived and rarely pass to the next generation, they can be instrumental in making long-lasting changes to the city, breaking apart conservative old ways and replacing outdated customs.

Cities are small, fewer than 5,000 people is the norm, not much more than a village by modern standards. And some are just that – a collection of villages, perhaps with a clutch of shrines they all share and some shared place for public gatherings. City walls might encompass just the city's key temple and shrines on a prominent and defensible piece of high ground, but ideally extend to embrace the whole of the core settlement. There are still isolated farmsteads, hamlets and villages out in the countryside, but many people simply commute out from the city to their fields every morning.

People can still be mobile – moving to a new city if things don't work out where they are. That can sometimes mean if things get rough, or if opportunity and advantage beckon, the whole city can move en masse to a new site and re-found their city, or merge with another city to make a bigger whole. Entrepreneurs and adventurers are heading out into the wider world, forging new trade links, or establishing trading posts and settlements in foreign lands that one day will turn into cities in their own right.

The people are divided into wealth classes according to what property they have, or what their land can produce, usually measured in grain, wine and oil. This sets both their social standing and the expectations placed on them, especially their role in defence of the city. Free men who cannot afford to deck themselves out in fine armour make up weight in the rear ranks, the poor might serve as missile troops.

Some aristocrats still have their own little private armies and fleets gathered from their extended family and retainers. They can use their might on behalf of the city. But they may equally hire out to foreign powers, or take their followers to capture control of another city or

found a new one somewhere on land won by the spear. And nothing is more likely to ignite conflict than land hunger. Cities attempt to incorporate new land into their territory, and sometimes those that live there already resist; or another city claims the same real estate, and the citizens of the opposing sides line up for battle. Even in peacetime some folk (usually the aristocrats) still go armed in public, wearing a sword, or perhaps leaning on a spear as a staff.

Slaves are few and are mostly attached to aristocratic households or the farms of the gentry. Money is still mostly represented by simple weight of metals, but minted coins are becoming more commonplace. Iron is plentiful but aristocrats still deck themselves out in flashy bronze armour when they go to war.

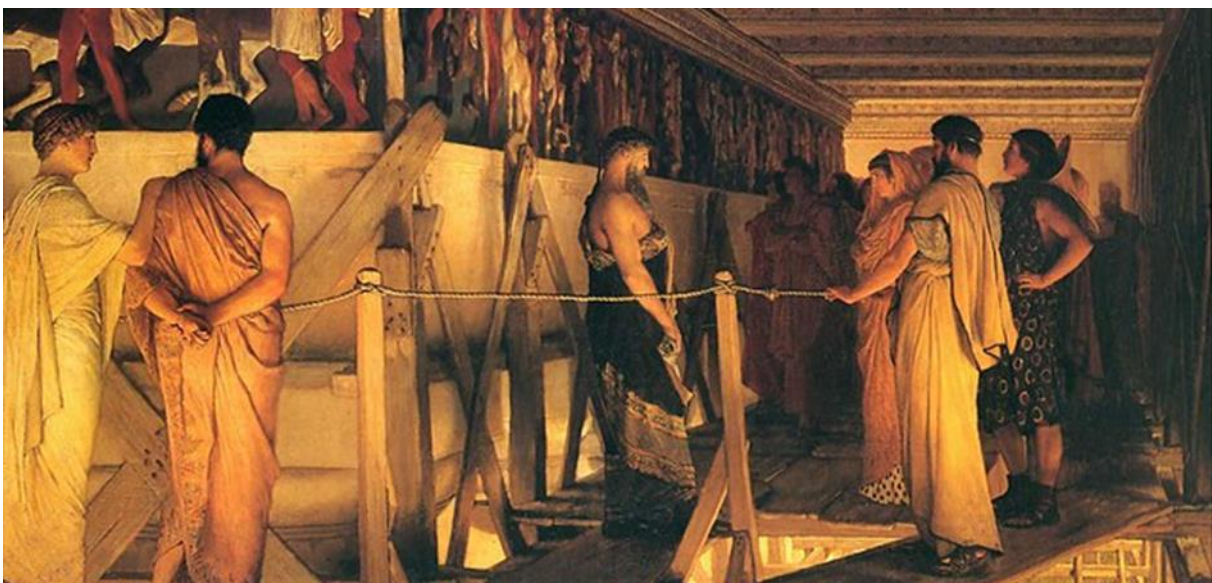
Classical World (Culture Type: Civilised)

There are backwaters where the ways of the Archaic World still hold true. Most cities are still 5,000 or fewer people, but now there are cities that have grown really fast and a handful number tens of thousands of people. Within a city's fine circuit of walls you will find temples and plazas, monuments and statues, theatres, meeting halls for the council and city leaders, an open space for the citizens to assemble. Bearing arms in public is strictly forbidden, the whole city is in a sense a sacred place not to be violated, or threatened, by violence (but of course it sometimes is).

Some cities now have too many people to feed themselves off their own lands, and increasingly depend on trade or empire to sustain themselves.. Goods are moving across significant distances and in ever increasing volumes. Any city worth its salt is minting coins in its own name, those that have access to gold or silver mines can literally just create the money they need

Many people are no longer tied to the land but pursue specialised crafts and occupations in the city. Slaves are becoming an increasingly large proportion of the total population, as are transient merchants and specialist artisans, who settle where they find the best market for their skills. Celebrated artists and architects create beautiful public buildings, monuments and temples, some so magnificent as to become enduring wonders of the age. Literacy is becoming widespread, even those of modest means can afford to send their children to a teacher to learn to read and write.

The people are sovereign. Membership of the citizenry is a privilege that comes with the right to own property in the city and its territory. And it comes with expectations to honour the city's gods and line up alongside your fellow citizens to fight its enemies. How much land and property you own still matters to your social standing - unless you live in a new-fangled democracy where anyone who isn't a woman, enslaved or foreign (so not exactly the majority) gets to enjoy equality under the law no matter



how rich or poor. Only foreigners pay taxes, but that is because the rich are expected to meet most of the costs of state out of their own purses. That can include paying to build and equip a warship, construct a temple, maintaining a stretch of the city walls, laying on lavish public feasts and festivals. In return they get the admiration, and presumably the votes, of their grateful fellow citizens. Conspicuous generosity on the part of the wealthy is burnt into the system. An obligation, not just a gesture.

Slavery is on the rise, especially where citizen freedoms mean the rich can't exploit the poor as much as they would like to. Incessant warfare adds to the growing pool of available captive human labour. Country estates are getting bigger as aristocrats amass large parcels of land and use slaves to boost the labour force. Some get rich from commercial business, setting up factories to make things every citizen needs (like shields for when they have to do militia service).

New money is elevating people who don't have genealogies going back to distant legendary heroes. Old school aristos can be very sniffy about 'new men', but it quickly becomes impossible to tell old and new money apart. Among the wider citizenry the proportion of the population directly involved in farming is dropping. There's more opportunity now for landless citizens to make a living in trade.

The cities all recognise each other as similar, but not as equals. Each imagines itself in some way special, the finest and best – if not in size and wealth, then in way of life. Cities are often in conflict, open warfare or raid and counter-raid, or in less violent but hotly contested competition at sports, or promoting themselves at internationally recognised religious sites by setting up the finest monuments. One city might encourage civil unrest in another by backing a political faction they think more friendly or useful – usually this comes down to backing oligarchs against democrats, or vice versa. It takes a big external threat that affects everyone for people to set aside their differences. Like when someone forces a lot of cities into unequal treaties as 'allies' and calls it leadership before expanding into foreign conquests and calling it Empire.

Warfare is the preserve of citizen militias, often led by elected generals, but it is increasing in scale, as large cities mobilise their population for war, and smaller cities fall in alongside them as allies. Battles can now feature tens of thousands of fighters instead of just a few thousand or a few hundred. War fleets, sometimes with hundreds of galleys rowed by poorer citizens who can also double up as light armed soldiers, make it possible for some cities to project their power overseas, controlling trade routes or building empires, and especially seizing land that can be turned to producing more food for the homeland.



Late Classical/Hellenistic World

The Classical World is still alive and kicking, but it's being swept up in an era of rapid growth, violent change, internationalism and empire-building conquerors. It's the age of supersizing. A few truly huge cities now boast populations in the hundreds of thousands. All across the city-state world people are reading the same literature, sporting the same fashions, and speaking in an increasingly common dialect that makes them look cosmopolitan and urbane. It serves as a 'common tongue' even with the educated classes among peoples for whom it is a foreign language.

Cities now feature whole clutches of majestic temples to the gods, lavishly fitted out and beautifully adorned, attracting tourists and pilgrims from far and wide. Supersized harbours are built to load or land vast grain transports and enormous warships. Awesome monuments, statues that tower over the city, marvels of civil engineering from city walls to sewage systems, stake claim to be the most sophisticated, prestigious, wealthy and advanced city around. Lavish tombs house the mortal remains of supersized personalities who have reached so high they begin to be worshipped as gods.

But out on the periphery of the city-state world some unexpected new players have been growing really fast too, and are now ready to assert themselves not just as part of the club of city-state civilizations, but as club president, secretary and treasurer all in one. And they are not afraid to re-write the rulebook. Because they bring different mentalities to the table (not least more than a passing interest in world domination), they will cherry-pick all the trappings of sophisticated living they need while diverting vast economic and human resources to their military. Offering paid employment to mercenary soldiers, engineers, and top-notch generals, they have armies that can not only outnumber, but out-fight, those rather old-fashioned citizen militias. The modern way is to go professional, and standing armies under equally professional generals are highly motivated to conquer and plunder (it's better by far than the basic pay).

A new generation of self-appointed kings and tyrants found new settlements, usually named after themselves, and force people to move there, creating more supersized cities seemingly overnight. The world is filling up with kingdoms and empires, and the city-states are now swept up into them or wedged in the gaps between rival powers. It's a perilous time: hundreds of thousands of people are enslaved and uprooted and thrown into the international slave market, while victorious soldiers carry vast quantities of portable treasure back from the wars to wherever they call (or intend to call) home. The rich find ways to get their hands on the greatest share of the proceeds of conquest and amass supersized landed estates, palatial houses in the best part of town, fashionable retreats in the hills or on the sea-shore to pass the summer months.

For those who are ready to embrace the new internationalised world there are now many ways to make a fortune that don't rely on simply inheriting real estate. Specialised crafts proliferate, as do slave trading, tax farming, and forging long distance trade routes to places that were previously thought little more than legendary. For the ruling classes that don't embrace joining the officer corps of the latest army of conquest, there are now a hugely diverse range of intellectual pursuits as lawyers, philosophers, historians, mathematicians, local politicians, or if they really strike it lucky, the very lucrative positions as governor of some conquered province.

Imperial Age World

The city-states are no longer in control of their own destinies. An unstoppable imperial power has conquered, destroyed, absorbed almost every city into one vast Empire (with a capital E) containing millions of people. Only trackless deserts, broad oceans, high mountain ranges and impenetrable forests halt its expansion. The Empire is big enough to shrug off natural, man-made and god-sent disasters, because they almost never affect all of it. Conversely the creation of a single vast political space in which everything is connected means that not only goods and people, but new ideas, new religious cults and increasingly deadly plagues all



happily make use of the roads, sea lanes and trade routes the Empire provides. Across the empire whole regions may now specialise in specific industries and produce, from timber to pickled fish, supplying not only the imperial capital but all the provinces of the empire, in which increasingly the same products are in vogue and in demand. Fashions radiate back out to the provinces where provincial elites ape the lifestyle of the Imperial heartland. Not everyone benefits. Some regions that once were celebrated for their prosperity and thriving populations have lost out as people, trade and wealth are now attracted elsewhere, leaving them a shadow of their former glory.

At the Empire's heart is an extraordinary megacity, the biggest ever seen – or that will ever be seen again for centuries to come. The capital sucks in people from all over the Empire and even beyond, willingly or not. It consumes vast quantities of grain to feed its hungry inhabitants, is the destination for commodities and luxuries of every kind brought from all corners of the Empire, and even mysterious lands across the ocean. It's big enough that entire regions and industries are directed at serving the insatiable demands of the capital. The city streets and the tenement blocks that glower over them are crammed with people, a diverse, thrilling, dangerous, glorious and squalid press of humanity. Disease is rife and picks off unwary newcomers quicker than the thugs and footpads that haunt the night.

Paid work is hard to come by if you are not in the pocket of one of the rich families in their city mansions, but the Emperor looks after the common folk with doles of food, presents and coins. He entertains and awes them with extravagant and extraordinary public spectacles, thrilling chariot races, brutal bloodsports and displays of the exotica to be found on the far reaches of the Empire's frontier. They entertain themselves watching the brutal and murderous soap opera that is the imperial family and court, and the thrilling, if repetitive, season climaxes where someone major character's mutilated body ends up thrown down the steps of the palace.

Out in the provinces there are some quiet and peaceful backwaters, left alone to carry on much as they always did. Places with no reason to rebel and no foreign enemies at the gates. The distant Emperor wields so much power over so many lives that outside the capital he is like a god. Most people may know him only by the publication of decrees that affect their lives, a portrait struck onto the little coins tucked in the folds of their cloak or the lifelike statues set up in every public place. But there are always trouble-spots, regions that are routinely rebellious or close by untamed barbarian frontiers. These are stuffed with garrisons and military settlements to keep a lid on things, and if that doesn't work sometimes the Emperor himself has to put in an appearance.

The line between free and slave is increasingly blurred. Many of the free are themselves ex-

slaves or the children of slaves. The value of citizenship is declining, only wealth makes you powerful. But joining the army remains an attractive option. There are the usual pay and benefits, although these days there are few lands left to conquer so opportunities for plunder are a bit scarce. A good rebellion can be a fine opportunity for the troops sent to put it down. But now it is the troops themselves who ultimately choose who gets to be Emperor and are the biggest risk of rebellion. If they decide the current ruler is failing to be generous enough to his soldiers, if they disapprove of his scandalous personal life, or simply like someone else more, the army is capable of overthrowing one ruler and installing another. This is a form of people power just as much as it is about the rival generals who are vying for the top job. The result can be civil wars where rival wings of the army fight each other over who gets to be Emperor.

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